

Course Syllabus**GRAD-E1395 The Psychology of Intergroup Relations****1. General information**

Course Format	Onsite
Instructor(s)	Ruth Ditlmann
Instructor's E-mail	ditlmann@hertie-school.org
Assistant	Rebecca Nelson r.nelson@hertie-school.org
Instructor's Office Hours	TBD Please schedule with my assistant

Link to [Study, Examination and Admission Rules and MIA, MDS and MPP Module Handbooks](#)

For information on **course room, times and session dates**, please consult the [Course Schedule](#) on *MyStudies*.

Instructor Information:

Ruth Ditlmann, PhD is Professor of Social Psychology at the Hertie School. Previously she held postdoc positions at the Migration, Integration and Transnationalization Department of the WZB, and in the psychology department at Princeton University. She holds a PhD in Social Psychology from Yale University.

2. Course Contents and Learning ObjectivesCourse contents:

This course introduces students to the psychological science of prejudice and intergroup relations. We will be reading the cutting edge of psychological literature illuminating why we form groups, how groups can give rise to prejudice and when prejudice translates to discrimination. Moreover, we will learn to use scientific evidence to inform our understanding of human interaction and create research projects of our own.

The course will begin with an introduction to the science of intergroup relations and its methods and assumptions. From there we will move into social categorization and its consequences; theories that explain why we form groups based on social categorization process and social ideology. We will then discuss implicit and explicit theories of prejudice, when prejudice translates into discrimination and what implications are for those who experience discrimination. We will conclude the semester with a discussion of intergroup contact and intergroup interactions as potential remedies, other prejudice reduction interventions with a special focus on media interventions and their potential for impact, and conclude with a discussion of more recent work that brings together psychological perspectives on intergroup relations with structural theories of discrimination.

While the core of this research is US-based, we will read empirical articles testing these theories in different countries, pertaining to different group dynamics, whenever possible. In class discussions we will reflect together about the application of this work to non-US contexts of interest to the students. Moreover, while the core of the research we discuss uses scientific methods (e.g.,

questionnaires, experiments) to study intergroup relations, we will also read critical articles throughout that point to the limitations and even risks of these methods.

Main learning objectives:

1. You will be skilled in explaining important concepts related to the psychology of intergroup relations and applying them to your own life, work-context and public policy.
2. You will feel equipped to identify the pitfalls and promises of a variety of research approaches in the psychology of intergroup relations and appraise their utility in various contexts.
3. You will understand the micro-foundation of macro-level problems in areas such as human rights, social justice, national and international security, and migration.
4. You will know how to use findings from the science of intergroup relations to form and support your arguments in policy debates.

Teaching style:

The instructor and students (see assignment flashlight presentations) will give some input in the form of short presentations each week but a large portion of class time will be spent discussing ideas with your classmates. These discussions will be supplemented by videos, demonstrations, and activities to promote the learning and application of course material. You should read the assigned papers and listen to the assigned podcasts prior to class and give the material careful thought, as doing so will facilitate our class discussions and your understanding of the material. Asking questions and making comments during class is highly encouraged and necessary for a good participation grade

Prerequisites:

As we are going to read, evaluate, and apply original scientific research it is important that you have at least a basic understanding of the scientific method as well as statistical approaches, e.g., as acquired in Statistics I.

Diversity Statement:

Understanding and respect for all cultures and ethnicities is central to the teaching at Hertie. Being mindful of diversity is an important issue for policy professionals in the planning, implementation, and evaluation of programmes designed for specific groups, populations, or communities. I welcome all students in this course and expect that all students contribute to a respectful, welcoming and inclusive environment. If you have any concerns about classroom climate, please come to me to share your concerns. This course will not only touch on but also focus on disturbing aspects of human nature. I will endeavour to make it as comfortable and productive as possible, but it is likely that parts of the class will be upsetting. If you suspect that specific material is likely to be emotionally challenging for you, I'd be happy to discuss any concerns you have before the subject comes up in class. Likewise, if you ever wish to discuss your personal reactions to course material with the class or with me individually, I welcome such discussions as an appropriate part of our classwork. However, I do intend to centre class discussions on research we read and ask that if you must talk about events beyond that material, to speak only from personal experience.

If you ever feel the need to step outside (literally or figuratively) during a class discussion, you may always do so without academic penalty. You will, however, be responsible for any material you miss. If you do leave the room for a significant time, please make arrangements to get notes from another student or see me individually to discuss the situation.

3. Grading and Assignments

Policy on the use of AI tools for assignments

The use of generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT) is **permitted only for specific assignments**. Students must adhere to the specific instructions provided for each assignment. Where AI tools are used, students are expected to clearly indicate how they were used and to ensure the originality and academic integrity of their work. **Students must include a Statement of Authorship in all written assignments**. Improper or undisclosed use of AI tools may be considered a violation of academic integrity policies. Please consult the course instructor in case of doubt. Further guidance is available in the [Artificial Intelligence Tools at the Hertie School - Teaching Guidelines for Instructors and Students](#), including a template for the **Statement of Authorship**, under section 1.1.

Composition of Final Grade:

Assignment 1: Flashlight presentation	Deadline: Submit slides on Wednesday before your presentation no later than 9:00	Submit via Moodle	30%
Assignment 2: Reading Responses	Deadline: Wednesday before class, no later than 20:00	Submit via Moodle	15%
Assignment 3: Research paper	Deadline: December 5 th midnight	Submit via Moodle	40%
Participation grade			15%

Assignment Details

Assignment 1: Flashlight Presentation

Once during the semester, you will (either alone or in teams depending on class size) deepen your own and the class' understanding of the week's topic with a short presentation of ideas that relevant to the topic of the week.

To help me plan and coordinate the class, and to ensure your topic is appropriate, I ask that you send me a short description of your topic at least 1 week before your presentation so that I can approve it. Your presentation should involve two components: First, clearly and concisely describe the main ideas in a 7 minutes presentation, and second, facilitate a 10 minutes discussion through discussion questions in class. Limit the use of text on your slides and instead focus on visual aids. A good goal is to have no more than 20 words on each slide. The challenge is to be extremely selective in what you want to talk about, focusing only on a few central messages. You can have as many images and graphics on your slides as you like, and the use of videos is encouraged. Good visuals will be essential as you try to present all the content you need to cover while limiting your use of written text.

Ideas for Flashlight Presentation:

- Empirical papers that test the theories of the week in a context outside of North-America and Europe (I can help you identify appropriate peer-reviewed papers)
- Application to self or others: Build on research presented in class to reduce your own intergroup bias or that of people around you, e.g., students at Hertie and report about your efforts and success or failure (this is only possible in some weeks, I will provide more information during sign-up).
- Application to policy: Present a policy case that you understand better or differently in light of the research we discuss during that week.

Assignment 2: Reading Responses

To facilitate class discussion you are expected to complete all the readings every week. In addition you earn credit for submitting up to four reading responses during the semester. Reading responses are graded based on completion, meaning that as long as you submit a response that meets the basic requirements (described below), you will earn credit.

Grading Scale:

4 completed reading responses	100%
3 completed reading responses	85%
2 completed reading responses	80%
1 completed reading responses	75%

Because you have a chance to complete a reading response every week, late submissions do not count and there will be not extensions. If you do not manage to submit your response on time, you can submit a response in another week, up to the maximum of four. If you wish, you can complete a reading response in the same week as you give your flashlight presentation.

Format Requirements: Submit your reading response as a **Word document** through Moodle using the provided link. Your response should:

- List the four prompts in bold
- Provide an answer of at least 300 words **per prompt**.
- Use Times New Roman, 12-point-font, single-spaced formatting.

Be prepared for in-class participation: Be prepared to contribute especially actively to the discussion of readings during the weeks when you completed your reading response. I will call on people who I know completed a reading response during a given week, when nobody else knows the answer.

Prompts:

- Prompt 1: What is the main idea or argument and what is the evidence presented in support of it?
- Prompt 2: How does this reading connect to your personal or professional experience, interests or challenges you have faced?
- Prompt 3: What are gaps the reading does not address, either in terms of shortcomings in the presented evidence, or ideas it fails to consider?
- Prompt 4: How does this reading build on previous class discussions? What similarities or differences stand out to you?.

Question Section: In a final, shorter section called “questions” you should propose at least one question (as short as one sentence) that you would like to discuss with the class that week. I will select a few of the group’s discussion questions each week and present them to everyone for discussion.

Assignment 3: Research Proposal

A major part of assessment of the course is based on different components of a semester-long research project and paper. At the beginning of the term, you will join a research group of three students based on your general topic interests. You will work with your group to come up with a broad research topic area. Then each of you will review the literature covering a narrower research topic within the broader scope of the group’s topic area. With the collective expertise gained from the individual literature reviews, the group will then decide on a specific research question, propose one or more hypotheses, describe and develop a suitable design for addressing the question, and discuss theoretical and practical implementations if your predictions are confirmed or not. The methods you propose should be similar to the ones you will see in the papers we discuss throughout the semester, mostly laboratory, survey, and field experiments, or observational studies (the instructor will guide you through the process of selecting an appropriate method). Formally, each group will submit an APA-report in the style of a scientific paper. This assignment serves two main purposes. First, it is an opportunity for us to immerse ourselves in questions that interest us. This class can only scratch the surface not only of the topics we will discuss, but of the topics that are available in the psychology of intergroup relations. Second, it is a chance to experience and learn more about the scientific process in this field of study, and by extension require a better, critical understanding of the evidence base. To promote this second goal, you will also write a section where you critically reflect on the research process and methods - considering the topic, your positionality, the context of the research and the potential applicability of the results for public policy.

Participation grade

The participation grade assumes that students take part, not as passive consumers of knowledge, but as active participants in the exchange, production, and critique of ideas—their own ideas and the ideas of others. Therefore, students should come to class not only having read and viewed the materials assigned for that day but also prepared to discuss the readings and to contribute thoughtfully to the conversation. Participation is marked by its active nature, its consistency, and its quality.

Late submission of assignments: For each day the assignment 3 is turned in late, the grade will be reduced by 10% (e.g., submission two days after the deadline would result in 20% grade deduction). There are no late submissions for assignments 1 and 2.

Attendance: Students are expected to be present and prepared for each class session. Active participation during lectures and seminar discussions is essential. Please note that students can miss up to two sessions (out of twelve) if no course assignments are affected. **Students do not need to inform the course instructor(s) in advance if they are unable to attend a session.** For further information please consult the [Examination Rules](#) §10.

Academic Integrity: The Hertie School is committed to the standards of good academic and ethical conduct. Any violation of these standards shall be subject to disciplinary action. Plagiarism, misuse of AI, free riding in group work, and other deceitful actions are not tolerated. See [Examination Rules](#) §16, the Hertie [Plagiarism Policy](#), and [the Hertie Guidelines for Artificial Intelligence Tools](#).

Compensation for Disadvantages: If a student furnishes evidence that he or she is not able to take an examination as required in whole or in part due to disability or permanent illness, the Examination Committee may upon written request approve learning accommodation(s). In this respect, the submission of adequate certificates may be required. See [Examination Rules](#) §14.

Extenuating circumstances: An extension can be granted due to extenuating circumstances (i.e., for reasons like illness, personal loss or hardship, or caring duties). In such cases, please contact the course instructors and the Examination Office *in advance* of the deadline.

4. Course Sessions and Readings

Please refer to Moodle to access the course readings.

Session 1 (Date): Introduction to the Psychology of Intergroup Relations	
Learning Objective	Understand how Social Psychology approaches the study of intergroup relations including opportunities and challenges
Required Readings	Eberhardt, J. (2020). <i>Biased: Uncovering the Hidden Prejudice that shapes what we see, think, and do</i> . Penguin Books. Read chapter 6. KW pp. 4-31
Optional Readings	Dovidio, J. F., Newheiser, A.-K., & Leyens, J.-P. (2012). A history of intergroup relations research. In A. W. Kruglanski & W. Stroebe (Eds.), <i>Handbook of the history of social psychology</i> (pp. 407–429). Psychology Press. Read entire chapter. Eberhardt, J. (2020). <i>Biased: Uncovering the Hidden Prejudice that shapes what we see, think, and do</i> . Penguin Books. Introduction.

Session 2 (Date): Methods in the Psychology of Intergroup Relations	
Learning Objective	Learn what research methods social psychologists typically use when studying intergroup relations
Required Readings	KW. Chapter 2. Pages 46-51 and 76-80. West, K. (2025). <i>The Science of Racism: Everything you need to know but probably don't - yet</i> . Picador. Pages 9-40 and 272-274.
Optional Readings	Simons, D. J. (2014). The value of direct replication. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i> 9(1), 76–80. Stroebe, W. & Strack, F. (2014). The alleged crisis and the illusion of exact replication. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i> 9 (1), 59–71.

Session 3 (Date): Social Categorization and Prejudice	
Learning Objective	Learn about why and how we use social categories, and discuss what we mean when we talk about “race” and “ethnicity”
Required Readings	KW: p. 86 – p. 90 (why we categorize), p. 98-p.100 (consequences), p.100 – p.108 (cognitive origins of stereotypes). Juang, L. P., Moffitt, U., Schachner, M. K., & Pevec, S. (2021). Understanding ethnic-racial identity in a context where “race” is taboo. <i>Identity</i>, 21(3), 185-199. Read all. Watch: Why race is not based in genetics
Optional Readings	Czopp, A. M., Kay, A. C., & Cheryan, S. (2015). Positive stereotypes are pervasive and powerful. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i> , 10(4), 451-463.

Session 4 (Date): Theories of Intergroup Relations I: Social Identity Theory	
Learning Objective	Learn about Social Identity Theory that explains why and how we are quick to form groups and prefer our own group
Required Readings	KW: 303-309 (stop at Issues in Social Identity Theory). Van Bavel, J., & Packer, D. (2022). The power of us: Harnessing our shared identities for personal and collective success. Little, Brown Spark. Read chapter 1. Knowles, E. D., Lowery, B. S., Chow, R. M., & Unzueta, M. M. (2014). Deny, distance, or dismantle? How white Americans manage a privileged identity. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i>, 9(6). Read all. Klein, E. (2020). <i>Why We're Polarized</i>. Simon & Schuster, Inc. Read chapter: Your brain on groups. Littman, R. (2018). Perpetrating Violence Increases Identification with Violent Groups: Survey Evidence from Former Combatants. <i>Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin</i>, 44(7), 1077-1089.
Optional Readings	Liu, J. H., & Hilton, D. J. (2005). How the past weighs on the present: Social representations of history and their role in identity politics. <i>British Journal of Social Psychology</i>, 44(4). Van Bavel, J., & Packer, D. (2022). The power of us: Harnessing our shared identities for personal and collective success. Little, Brown Spark. Chapter 2.

Session 5 (Date): Theories of Intergroup Relations II: Right-Wing Authoritarianism and Social Dominance Theory	
Learning Objective	Discuss how social ideologies can serve the maintenance of group hierarchies and what partisanship has to do with prejudice
Required Readings	KW: 228-239. Sidanius, J., & Pratto, F. (2004). Social dominance theory: A new synthesis. In <i>Political Psychology</i> (pp. 315-332). Psychology Press. Read all. Crawford, J. T., & Brandt, M. J. (2020). Ideological (A) symmetries in prejudice and intergroup bias. <i>Current Opinion in Behavioral Sciences</i>, 34. Read all. Wetts, R., & Willer, R. (2022). Antiracism and its discontents: The prevalence and political influence of opposition to antiracism among White Americans. OSF preprint Kendi, X. I. (2022). My daughter's white doll: Was I right to worry? The Atlantic. https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2022/07/doll-test-history-racial-segregation-toy-diversity/638442/
Optional Readings	

Session 6 (Date): Consequences of Stereotypes for Targets	
Learning Objective	Learn about the psychological impact of experiencing discrimination and the psychology of resistance.
Required Readings	KW: p. 392-402, p. 411-434 Hatzenbuehler, M. L., McLaughlin, K. A., Keyes, K. M., & Hasin, D. S. (2010). The impact of institutional discrimination on psychiatric disorders in lesbian, gay, and bisexual populations: A prospective study. <i>American Journal of Public Health</i>, 100(3), 452-459. Read all. Phillips, N. L., Adams, G., & Salter, P. S. (2015). Beyond adaptation: Decolonizing approaches to coping with oppression. <i>Journal of Social and Political Psychology</i>, 3(1), 365-387.
Optional Readings	Johnson, A. L., Levesque, C., Lewis Jr, N. A., & Asad, A. L. (2024). Deportation threat predicts Latino US citizens and noncitizens' psychological distress, 2011 to 2018. <i>Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences</i>, 121(9), e2306554121. Vollhardt, J. R., Bilewicz, M., Zeineddine, I. F. B., & Vollhardt, J. R. (2024). Jewish resistance during the Holocaust: Influences on the choice between individual and collective resistance

	strategies. <i>Resistance to Repression and Violence: Global Psychological Perspectives</i> , 179.
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Session 7 (Date): Intergroup Contact

Learning Objective	Learn about the promises and potential pitfalls of bringing members of different groups together Practitioner Guest: More in Common Germany
Required Readings	KW: p. 536 – 548 Watch: Countering Discrimination: Generating Evidence and Policy Lessons . S. Mousa's presentation (the first 20 minutes) Hässler, T., Ullrich, J., Bernardino, M., Shnabel, N., Laar, C. V., Valdenegro, D., ... & Ugarte, L. M. (2020). A large-scale test of the link between intergroup contact and support for social change. <i>Nature Human Behaviour</i> , 4(4), 380-386. Read all.
Optional Readings	MacInnis, C. C., & Page-Gould, E. (2015). How can intergroup interaction be bad if intergroup contact is good? Exploring and reconciling an apparent paradox in the science of intergroup relations. <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i> , 10(3), 307-327. Read all. Dixon, J., Levine, M., Reicher, S., & Durrheim, K. (2012). Beyond prejudice: Are negative evaluations the problem and is getting us to like one another more the solution?. <i>Behavioral and Brain Sciences</i> , 35(06), 411-425. Enos, R. D. (2017). <i>The Space Between Us: Social Geography and Politics</i> . Cambridge University Press.

Session 8 (Date): Guest Lecture tbd

Learning Objective	
Required Readings	
Optional Readings	

Session 9 (Date): Guest Lecture tbd

Learning Objective:	Learn about the applied work by More in Common
Required Readings	

Optional Readings	
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Session 10 (Date): Theories of Intergroup Relations III: Structural Approaches

Learning Objective	Learn how to integrate a psychological with a structural perspective on discrimination
Required Readings	Luttrell, A. (2020, June 8). Systemic racism with Phia Salter (No 9). [Audio Podcast Episode]. <i>Opinion Science</i>. Andrew Luttrell Eberhardt, J. (2020). <i>Biased: Uncovering the Hidden Prejudice that shapes what we see, think, and do</i>. Penguin Books. Read p.276-293. Van Bavel, J., & Packer, D. (2022). The power of us: Harnessing our shared identities for personal and collective success. Little, Brown Spark. Read p. 165 – 172. Watch: Bias in Medicine: Last Week Tonight with John Oliver.
Optional Readings	Trawalter, S., Higginbotham, G. D., & Henderson, K. (2022). Social Psychological Research on Racism and the Importance of Historical Context: Implications for Policy. <i>Current Directions in Psychological Science</i>, 09637214221114092. Banaji, M. R., Fiske, S. T., & Massey, D. S. (2021). Systemic racism: individuals and interactions, institutions and society. <i>Cognitive research: principles and implications</i>, 6(1), 1-21. (p. 4-8 are recommended but optional)

Session 11 (Date): Intergroup Relations in Post-Conflict Societies

Learning Objective:	Learn about research on reconciliation in post-conflict societies
Required Readings	Čehajić-Clancy, S., Jamshed, N., Olsson, A., & Momčilović, A. (2024). From inspiration to restoration: Moral elevation as a catalyst for improving intergroup relations in contexts of conflict. <i>Journal of Personality and Social Psychology</i>. Take a look at the rescuer exhibition: https://proof.org/the-rescuers Vollhardt, J., Jeong, H., & Bilali, R. (2022). Reconciliation in the aftermath of collective violence. In D. Osborne, & C. Sibley (Eds.), <i>Cambridge Handbook of Political psychology</i> (pp. 582-600). Cambridge University Press. Read until page 589.
Optional Readings	Kteily, N. S., & Bruneau, E. (2017). Darker demons of our nature: The need to (re) focus attention on blatant forms of

	dehumanization. <i>Current Directions in Psychological Science</i> , 26(6), 487-494. Read all.
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Session 12 (Date): Interventions to Promote Positive Intergroup Relations	
Learning Objectives	Learn about the state of evidence on strategies and programs that can reduce prejudice, and the promise of media interventions.
Required Readings	Paluck, E. L., Porat, R., Clark, C. S., & Green, D. P. (2021). Prejudice reduction: Progress and challenges. <i>Annual Review of Psychology</i>, 72, 533-560. Read all. Bruneau, E., Casas, A., Hameiri, B., & Kteily, N. (2022). Exposure to a media intervention helps promote support for peace in Colombia. <i>Nature Human Behaviour</i>, 6(6), 847-857.
Optional Readings	Eberhardt, J. (2020). <i>Biased: Uncovering the Hidden Prejudice that shapes what we see, think, and do</i> . Penguin Books. Conclusion.